

7 from the pendrive will be much faster than by DVD.

Besides a Windows disk, it might be a good idea to keep a Linux disc / pen drive handy too. We would recommend BackTrack Linux 4. While it is based on the rather dated Ubuntu 8.10, BackTrack 4 is a Linux distribution designed for penetration testing. You can download a liveDVD of the OS from their web site: <http://www.backtrack-linux.org/>. Using a tool such as Unetbootin, you can easily transfer this disk image to a pendrive and boot off that. Linux can be very useful for debugging Windows problems as well, and often allows you to access your system at a lower level than you could with Windows. However, for full fledged NTFS support, and to manipulate your computers registry offline, it is better to use a Windows recovery disk / pendrive.

5.2 The Windows registry

For all the people using Windows, it is very helpful to learn about one of the most important aspects of any windows system, the Windows Registry. The registry in Windows is a central database of all configuration settings for most of the applications installed on your computer. It is used extensively by Windows for storing all its settings and by most Windows applications. The Windows registry allows one to configure many settings for Windows and other application which are otherwise not accessibly by any interface that the application provides.

By understanding a few things about the Windows registry you can go a long way towards hacking your system into what you want it to be. Editing the Windows registry is one of the most powerful ways of manipulating you system settings, which is something that makes it equally dangerous. It is a minefield filled with often cryptic configuration parameters which usually affect your system in ways you won't even notice. It can completely mess up your system in such a way that you are unable to even boot into Windows. Modify the right hardware setting, and your hardware gets a boost, modify the wrong one, and you end up with a non-booting system.

So before you set out to do anything with the registry, please back up your system registry. If you are using the System Restore / System Protection feature in Windows create a recovery point. Before going into your registry and editing things indiscriminately, read up about what you want to accomplish – Google is your friend here, unless you use Bing ;-) – to get an idea of what you might need to change. Before you edit your registry see if there is any way to change the setting in an way supported by the application. Wait, this is book about hacking right? Disregard that!

Even so, there are many tools out there which will help you accomplish some advanced registry manipulations without needing to edit it manually.